

feedback. Slightly less painful—but painful nevertheless—are the too-soft mouse keys. The Presario v3225AU also has a slightly flawed keypad: use it a bit and you'll notice the keys have too much travel. However, keypad feedback is largely subjective, and some people like soft keypads. (We don't.) On a positive note, the layout of the keypad is very good.

All the ACI laptops except for the Ethos C have great keypad feedback. Our gripe was the lack of shortcut keys—an Internet key and a media player button just do not cut it. The Ethos C does feature shortcut keys to switch off Wi-Fi and the touchpad, though.

The Zenith Director with its silver and grey colour tones will appeal to the corporate user segment, which, as you can see from the name, is its intended audience. The only ergonomic issue we could find was the largish spacing between the keys—not good unless you're used to it. The Presidio, too, featured a great keypad, and in a tiny body. We didn't place this one in the ultra-portable category because of its weight and thickness.

Intex's M54N doesn't feature a very good finish, but we'll forgive that considering the price. What we won't forgive is the tacky, chromed shortcut key buttons. The carry bag is beautiful and sturdy.

Some of the ACI laptops—the Ethos series—feature a little subwoofer directly underneath the touchpad. This is supposed to provide improved bass, but it just doesn't!

Performance

The Core Duo processors here gobble up all the benchmarks that have anything to do with number-crunching.

The second-most important aspect of a laptop is the storage subsystem, which often becomes a bottleneck.

The two LG RD400s and the Compaq Presario v3225AU have a strong storage subsystem, as the scores testify. If your applications lean towards this trend—for example, transferring large files, or opening large images in Photoshop, you know where to look—at this price point.

The ACI Duo 1430 and 1430D offer very good multimedia performance, as their scores in 3D Mark 2005 and our game tests revealed. This makes them suitable for playing the occasional game... movie playback is also guaranteed to be skip-free, although the quality of the LCD panel should have been better, in keeping with such good graphics performance.

The Conclusion

The Presario v3225AU isn't shy on features, with touch controls similar to that of the DV series, and dedicated buttons for wireless connectivity—not to mention superb build and attractive looks. This one just had to be a winner. The Digit Best Buy Gold is with the



Zenith Director
Sturdy, rugged, great value

Compaq Presario v3225AU: unbeatable value at Rs 32,990.

The T2350-powered Zenith Director is our Digit Best Buy Silver winner: unbeatable value and great performance for the price—only Rs 29,700.

If you want something half-decent to game with in this price category, ACI is the only way to go, with the Ethos Duo 1430D actually featuring NVIDIA graphics hardware (the GeForce Go 7300 series).

If you're looking at something compact at a ridiculously low price, the Zenith Presidio will surely please your aesthetic sensibilities as well as your wallet. At Rs 28,700, it's a steal. Drop in a little more memory and watch this little notebook really run—very suitable for most everyday applications.

PERFORMANCE LAPTOPS

There exists a cadre of users that will not be satisfied with just *good* performance at a value-for-money price point. They'll want better graphics—perhaps a discrete graphics solution; more CPU horsepower; and memory bandwidth to handle it. These are the users who will also be likely to need more storage space. We discuss, in this section, laptops that cater to this user profile.

Features

There was a lot of beauty in this category—from the dusky, all-black, matte-finished Lenovo R61 ThinkPad, to the flashy and even more eye-catching HP DV6226tx. While the R61 seems to draw you in subtly, the DV6226tx simply grabs you by the scruff and demands attention with the kind of piano finishes we've seen on much more expensive hardware. Equally attractive is ASUS' F3Jc: it features a very pleasing black and dark grey finish.

The LG X Note P1 has a very alluring shape, and the quality of fit and finish is excellent. The white, matte-finished body immediately attracts more than just a cursory glance. A pity they used navy blue on the lid—it gives the effect of a school uniform. Or could that have been intentional...?

Once again, the coating treatment given to the DV6226tx's palm-rest, ditto the outer lid, is absolutely top-notch. Equally tasteful is the subtle and flowing patterns adorning the entire top body and inside, which we're told is inspired from Japanese rice fields. It seems, in Japan, paddy is grown not in straight rows but in flowing, curved patterns. Whatever the inspiration, the result is stunning!

Equally cool are the media buttons above the keypad: they're touch-activated and a cool backlit blue! Also bundled is a tiny IR remote for Media Center purposes. This tasteful blue extends to the power jack area, which will illuminate when the adapter is connected to the mains. All this blue is attractive without hitting you in the face in any way. The speaker grille is also attractive, and proudly sports "Altec Lansing." As we'd expected,



Compaq Presario v3225AU
Exceptionally good value